Substance Dualism

Descartes' indivisibility and conceivability arguments, and the problems of interaction and other minds

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
3. Quick recall
4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

> **Key Thesis**
> There are two categories of substance: **physical substance**, whose essence is to be extended (to take up space), and **mental substance**, whose essence is to think (be conscious). The mind is a substance, not a property, and it is not identical to the body or to any part of it.

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can...	Start	End
define substance, essence, extension and substance dualism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
set out the indivisibility argument in standard form	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
set out the conceivability argument, with and without God	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain two responses to each argument	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain Elisabeth's conceptual interaction problem and the empirical (conservation) problem	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the problem of other minds and two responses	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on whether substance dualism is true	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Substance	
Essence	
Extension	
Leibniz's law	
Indivisible	
Conceivable	
Metaphysically possible	
Interactionism	

	Definition
A	Able to be thought of clearly and without contradiction.
B	Could genuinely be so, in some possible world, given the natures of the things involved.
C	Something that can exist by itself, independently of other things; it has properties but is not itself a property.
D	Not able to be split into parts. Descartes claims this is true of the mind but not of the body.
E	If X and Y are identical, every property X has, Y also has (the indiscernibility of identicals).
F	Taking up space; having length, breadth and depth. Descartes' essence of body.
G	The view that mind and body causally affect each other in both directions.
H	The property a thing must have to be the thing it is; if it is lost, the thing is destroyed.

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: extension · parts · possible · substance · Elisabeth · Leibniz's law · thought · body

Descartes argues that the mind is a _____ whose essence is _____, whereas the body's essence is _____. In the indivisibility argument he claims that he cannot detect any _____ within his mind, whereas the body is always divisible; so by _____ mind and body cannot be identical. In the conceivability argument he claims he can clearly and distinctly conceive of himself existing without his _____. Critics reply that what is conceivable may not be metaphysically _____. Princess _____ of Bohemia asked how a thinking, non-extended substance could cause voluntary movement.

Task 3 · In your own words

Explain, in no more than five sentences, why Descartes thinks the mind is a substance and not a property. Use the words *essence* and *extension*.

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. What are the two kinds of substance for Descartes, and what is the essence of each?

2. State Leibniz's law.

3. Which property does the indivisibility argument claim the mind has and the body lacks?

4. Why, for Descartes, are willing, understanding and perceiving not parts of the mind?

5. Give one example of something physical that is arguably not divisible.

6. What role does God play in Descartes' version of the conceivability argument?

7. What is the empirical interaction problem?

8. Summarise Mill's analogical argument for other minds.

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

How to use this section

Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

The indivisibility argument (Descartes, Meditations VI)

> *'When I consider the mind — i.e. consider myself purely as a thinking thing — I can't detect any parts within myself; I understand myself to be something single and complete'*
>
> — Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy, VI (as given on your slide)*

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, the mind is not identical to the body: it is a distinct substance.
	By Leibniz's law, if mind and body were identical they would share all properties.
	Mind and body have different properties (one is divisible, the other not).
	Every body (physical thing) is divisible into parts.
	The mind cannot be divided into parts: it is single and complete.

→ Which premise do the split-brain cases and psychological 'sections' of the mind attack?

_____

_____

_____

→ Explain why the 'belonging to the human race' example threatens premise 2.

_____

_____

_____

The conceivability argument (with God, as on your slides)

Order	Jumbled line
	I can clearly and distinctly conceive of myself as a thinking, non-extended thing.
	Therefore, mind and body are distinct substances.
	So God could make mind exist without body: they are capable of being separated.
	Things that can be separated are really distinct.

Order	Jumbled line
	God can bring about anything I clearly and distinctly conceive.
	I can clearly and distinctly conceive of body as an extended, non-thinking thing.

→ Why is the reliance on God a weakness of this version?

→ The deep-sleep objection: what does it show about thought being the mind's *essence*?

The conceivability argument without God (the spec version)

This is the version the specification asks for. Notice that premise 2 now does the work God did before.

Order	Jumbled line
	Whatever is conceivable is metaphysically possible.
	It is conceivable that I (my mind) exist without being extended.
	No physical body could possibly exist without being extended.
	So it is possible that I exist without being extended.
	Therefore, I am not identical to any physical body.

→ Which premise do the three spec responses attack? Name the premise for each.

→ Use the Cheshire cat example to challenge premise 4.

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
The mind is divisible	Split-brain patients; different psychological 'sections' of the mind with different functions.			
Not everything physical is divisible	Can you divide 'belonging to the human race'? A shape? A mass?			
Mind without body is not conceivable	Are you really conceiving a disembodied mind, or just failing to notice the body?			
Conceivable ≠ metaphysically possible	Water without H_2O seems conceivable: is it possible? The masked man fallacy.			
Possible ≠ actual	Even if mind *could* exist apart from body, does that show it *does*?			
Elisabeth's conceptual problem	How can something with no extension push or move anything?			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Empirical problem (conservation)	Momentum/energy in a closed system stays constant.			
Problem of other minds	I only ever see bodies, never minds.			
Category mistake (Ryle) — spec point	Like asking to see 'the university' after visiting every college.			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

Least damaging: _____ because...

Building a judgement

Is substance dualism true? Choose the argument for it you think is strongest, then the objection that hurts it most. Decide whether the objection can be answered.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06 Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by 'substance dualism'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain the indivisibility argument for substance dualism.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Define substance dualism and Leibniz's law.
2. Premise: the mind is indivisible (single and complete).
3. Premise: bodies are divisible.
4. Conclude: by Leibniz's law they differ, so are not identical.

12 marks · Explain the conceivability argument for substance dualism and how one response challenges it.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. State the conceivability argument without God, in standard form.
2. Explain *why* each premise is held (clear and distinct conception; the link from conceivability to possibility).
3. Explain one response (e.g. what is conceivable may not be metaphysically possible), with the water/H_2O example.
4. Show precisely which premise the response attacks and why it would then fail.

Extra notes

25 marks · Is substance dualism true?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	The indivisibility argument → divisibility objections → Descartes' reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 2	The conceivability argument → conceivable ≠ possible → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	The interaction problem (Elisabeth and conservation) → possible replies → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	The problem of other minds or Ryle's category mistake → replies → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

_____

_____

Part 07 Answers

> **How to use this section**
> Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Substance = C · Essence = H · Extension = F · Leibniz's law = E · Indivisible = D · Conceivable = A · Metaphysically possible = B · Interactionism = G

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) substance · (2) thought · (3) extension · (4) parts · (5) Leibniz's law · (6) body · (7) possible · (8) Elisabeth

Quick recall

1. Mental substance (essence: thought/consciousness) and physical substance (essence: extension).
2. If X and Y are identical, they share all their properties; so if they differ in one property, they are not identical.
3. Indivisibility: the mind has no parts; the body is divisible.
4. Because it is one and the same mind that wills, understands and perceives: they are faculties of a single thing, not separable parts.
5. E.g. the property of belonging to the human race; a mass or a shape; a single fundamental particle such as an electron (on some views).
6. God guarantees that whatever Descartes clearly and distinctly conceives as separate could be made separate, so conceivability shows real distinctness.
7. Physics says momentum/energy is conserved in a closed physical system, so a non-physical mind adding motion would break physical law.
8. My mind causes my behaviour; others behave as I do; like effects have like causes; so others probably have minds too.

Arguments in order

The indivisibility argument (Descartes, Meditations VI)

1. The mind cannot be divided into parts: it is single and complete.
2. Every body (physical thing) is divisible into parts.
3. By Leibniz's law, if mind and body were identical they would share all properties.
4. Mind and body have different properties (one is divisible, the other not).
5. Therefore, the mind is not identical to the body: it is a distinct substance.

The conceivability argument (with God, as on your slides)

1. I can clearly and distinctly conceive of myself as a thinking, non-extended thing.
2. I can clearly and distinctly conceive of body as an extended, non-thinking thing.
3. God can bring about anything I clearly and distinctly conceive.
4. So God could make mind exist without body: they are capable of being separated.
5. Things that can be separated are really distinct.
6. Therefore, mind and body are distinct substances.

The conceivability argument without God (the spec version)

1. It is conceivable that I (my mind) exist without being extended.
2. Whatever is conceivable is metaphysically possible.
3. So it is possible that I exist without being extended.
4. No physical body could possibly exist without being extended.
5. Therefore, I am not identical to any physical body.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
The mind is divisible	Descartes: these are faculties or effects of damage to the brain the mind works through, not divisions of the mind itself; the unity of consciousness remains.
Not everything physical is divisible	A defender may say these are properties, not substances; every physical *substance* is still divisible. The objection works best against premise 2 if a physical substance is indivisible.
Mind without body is not conceivable	Descartes: introspection shows nothing belongs to my essence but thought, so the conception is clear and distinct.
Conceivable ≠ metaphysically possible	Defenders can argue that ideal, clear and distinct conceiving is a reliable guide; but the water/H_2O case shows we can be ignorant of an identity.

Objection	Possible response
Possible ≠ actual	Descartes: for distinctness, possible separation is enough. Identity is necessary, so if mind and body could come apart, they are not identical.
Elisabeth's conceptual problem	Descartes: mind and body are 'intermingled' as a unit, not like a sailor in a ship; but this names the union rather than explaining it.
Empirical problem (conservation)	Perhaps the mind redirects rather than adds energy; or causation may not need energy transfer (counterfactual view).
Problem of other minds	Mill's analogy; inference to the best explanation; Wittgenstein's private language argument.
Category mistake (Ryle) — spec point	Dualist: 'mind' is not just a way of talking about behaviour; first-person experience is a real thing that needs a home.